MADHYA PRADESH

FLIGHT OF THE FAITHFUL



ANI

CHANGING SIDES
Deepak Joshi (garlanded) joining the Congress in the presence of Kamal Nath

By Rahul Noronha

It was a political earthquake of sorts when, in 2020, Jyotiraditya Scindia led a coup that felled the Kamal Nath government and enabled the formation of the BJP government in Madhya Pradesh. The true gauge of its intensity is that its aftershocks are still being felt now—even if in reverse. With assembly election just about six months away, the realignment of political loyalties has begun. And the Congress is the first to draw blood, that too with a prize catch. Senior BJP leader Deepak Joshi is not just a three-term MLA and minister, but no less than the son of late chief minister Kailash Joshi—with deep roots in the Jana Sangh and the BJP.

On May 6, he joined the Congress in Bhopal in the presence of state Congress chief Kamal Nath. The day also saw another BJP leader, former BSP MLA Radhelal Baghel, changing sides.

Joshi's flight to the Congress was not sudden. In fact, the script for his move was sealed in 2020 when 25 MLAs had defected from the Congress to the BJP. Among them was Manoj Chaudhary, who had defeated Joshi in Hatpipliya in the 2018 assembly poll. It was in March 2020 that he crossed over, one among the first batch of 22 migrant MLAs. Then he contested the byelection to fill the vacancy caused by his own defection—this time as a BJP candidate—and won again. It is likely that Chaudhary will be given the BJP ticket again in 2023. That would have left Joshi with the sour end of the bargain. He had made his displeasure very clear to top state leaders but got no assurance. Last-ditch efforts to stop Joshi's exit by state in-charge Muralidhar Rao and Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan went in vain.

DEEPAK JOSHI'S EXIT SCRIPT WAS SEALED IN 2020 WHEN 25 CONGRESS MLAs DEFECTED TO THE BJP

On the day he made the shift, Joshi used the dais to berate his former party and its leaders. "I have no demand for a Congress ticket. I was touched by the concern shown by Kamal Nathji when my father passed away. The BJP has shown disrespect towards my father," said Joshi. He also carried a picture of his late father to the event. Among other charges Joshi levelled was that he was labelled a 'terrorist' by BJP leaders in Dewas, his home district. Sources say Joshi is not likely to be fielded from Hatpipliya but from neighbouring Khategaon. This would ensure that Congress leaders in Hatpipliya are not adversely affected.

The circumstances that led Joshi to join the Congress are valid for a number of other BJP leaders too. Will they take Joshi's route too? After the March 2020 crop of 22 MLAs—most of them loyalists of now-Union minister Scindia—three more Congress MLAs had joined the BJP in the following weeks. Keeping with the 'understanding', all 25 were fielded as BJP candidates in byelections in November 2020, and 18 of them won. This meant the BJP was saddled with some dead weight: 18 old-timers who had lost in 2018 and then been left in the lurch.

This disaffected bunch largely adopted a wait-and-watch policy, despite their political survival being at stake. Besides Joshi, the disgruntled leaders include former ministers Rustam Singh, Gauri Shankar Shejwar (whose son unsuccessfully contested the 2018 election), Lal Singh Arya, Jai Bhan Singh Pawaiya and former MLA Bhanwar Singh Shekhawat, the last of whom even spoke out against the party decision to take in Rajvardhan Singh Dattigaon from the Congress and field him in the 2020 polls. Currently a minister, Dattigaon is likely to get the BJP ticket again, leaving Shekhawat with few options. There were others too who took a call in 2020 itself—Ajab Singh Kushwaha and Satish